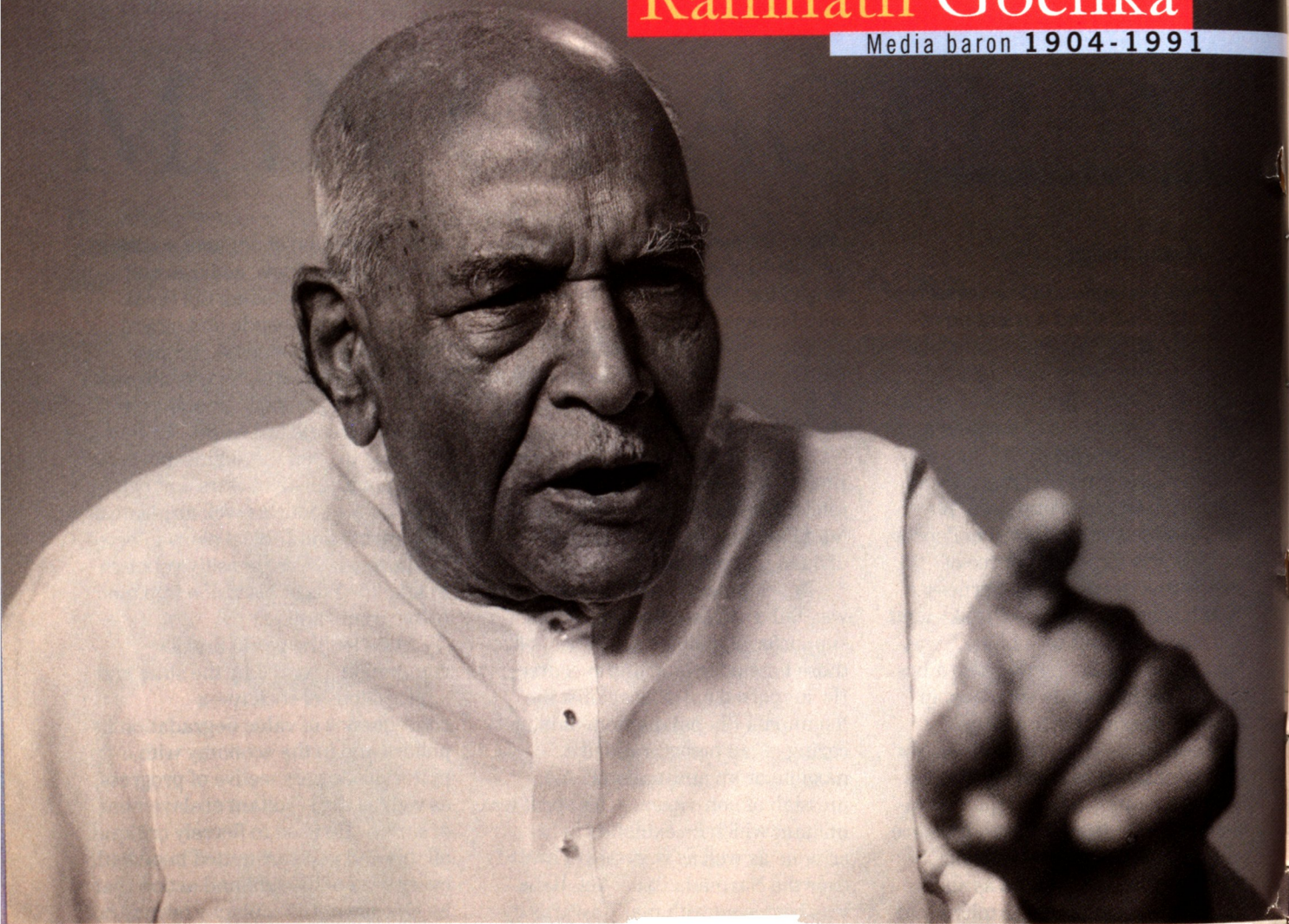


"I have committed every crime in the Indian Penal

Ramnath Goenka

Media baron 1904-1991



BHAWAN SINGH

# THE KINGMAKER

An epic antagonist of the Emergency, a good friend and a dangerous adversary, he made history, not all of it necessarily glorious

■ By B.G. Verghese

Whether loved or hated, admired or feared, Ramnath Goenka, or RNG, simply cannot be ignored. He was a good friend but a dangerous adversary. He made history, not all of it necessarily glorious. But he will always be remembered for his doughty defence of freedom of the press and any ruse to curtail its viability and independ-

ence through controls and constraints which climaxed in his epic opposition to the 1975 Emergency.

RNG's motto was never to seek trouble, but to fight with all his might, throwing everything into the battle if thwarted or opposed. He was an ardent nationalist and a self-appointed Congress quartermaster general during the 1942 movement, supplying explosives to the Quit India revolutionaries underground and printing sub-

versive literature for dissemination at home and abroad. He was never in government. But he was something of a kingmaker on account of his remarkable political connections, built up from his early days as a Congress worker and a servant of the freedom movement. He was quick to realise that without the media, the Congress message would scarcely reach the masses. He accordingly made it his business to build a nationalist trumpet.